Lead service line need is not one problem

States face different mixes of identification and replacement work

Where are infrastructure needs greatest across U.S. states?

01 IDENTIFY

Resolve Lead Status Unknown lines

Identification Need
= Lead Status Unknown

02 REPLACE

Act on known Lead and GRR lines

Known Replacement Inventory
= Lead + GRR

Comparing states on only one measure would hide where their actual workload sits.

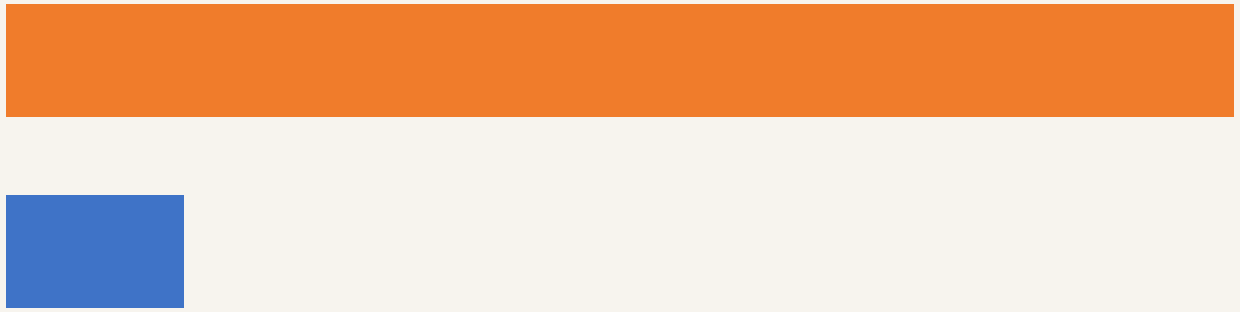
Scope: 43,993 complete-report Community Water Systems across 50 states and DC

Most of the reported national workload is still unresolved identification

National inventory within the analytical sample

Lead Status Unknown

21.59M



Known Replacement Inventory

3.12M 2.18M Lead + 0.94M GRR

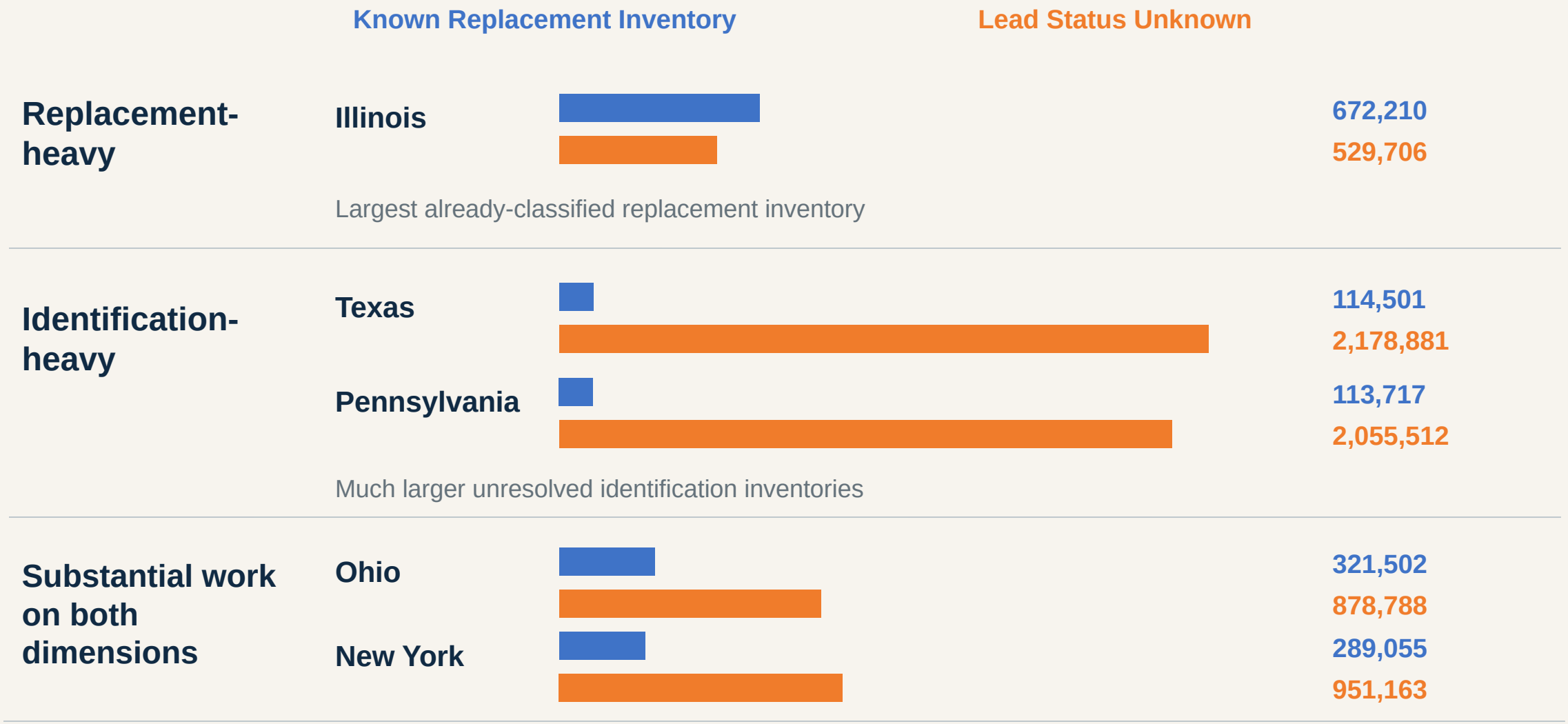
6.9×

as many Unknown lines as lines already classified for replacement

Unknown lines require identification.
They are not confirmed lead lines.

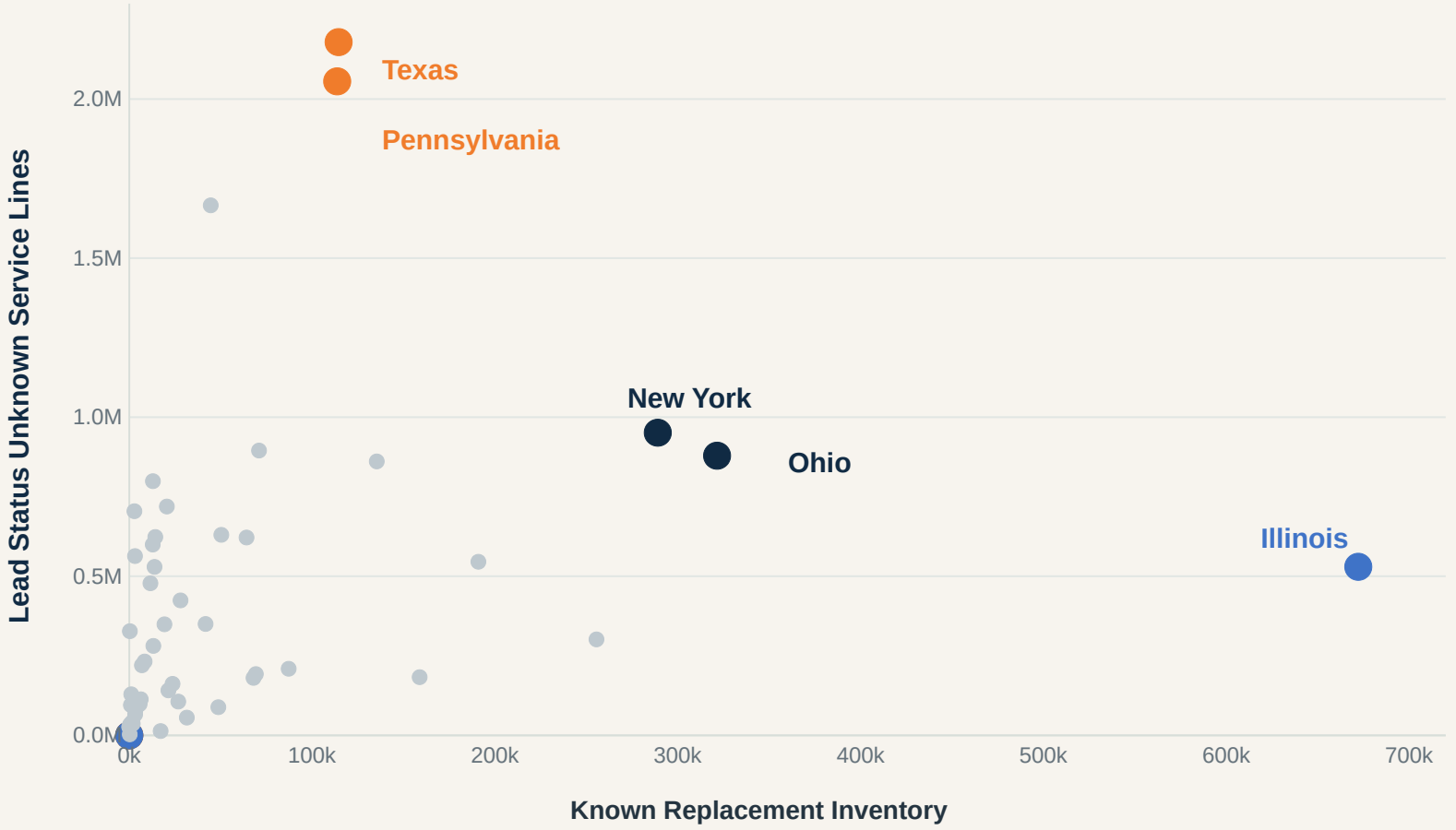
Source: U.S. EPA 2026 Q2 Service Line Inventory. Counts reflect the analytical sample.

The same national challenge looks very different from state to state



Source: U.S. EPA 2026 Q2 Service Line Inventory. Narrative examples, not statistical clusters. All bars use the same scale.

A single ranking would hide where each state's workload sits



What this reveals

Replacement and identification needs do not consistently move together.

One overall "need" ranking would hide these differences.

Planning should distinguish known replacement work from inventory still requiring identification.

This pattern describes inventory. It does not measure progress, maturity, or cause.

Source: U.S. EPA 2026 Q2 Service Line Inventory. Each point represents one state or DC.

State size changes who stands out, and local evidence is needed before acting

Absolute workload

Raw totals show where the largest overall inventories are concentrated.

Relative scale

Per 10,000 state residents

Raw top 10 retained after normalization

6 of 10 Known Replacement

3 of 10 Identification Need

Illinois: #1 Known Replacement
Pennsylvania: #1 Unknown

Both per 10,000 state residents

Rhode Island, Louisiana and New Mexico become more visible.

Decision implication

State inventories can guide deeper local investigation.

Intervention decisions require utility-level records, GIS information, inspections, funding information, local capacity, project plans and other local evidence.

Next question **How do state and utility identification and replacement needs align with available funding and local capacity to complete service-line replacement?**

Unknown does not mean lead. Inventory does not measure exposure or water quality. Incomplete-report systems are excluded.

Sources: U.S. EPA 2026 Q2 Service Line Inventory; U.S. Census Bureau 2025 resident population estimates (population context).